

Gurumanie Singh Dhiman

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Prof. Guan, Yong

## **Forensic Tool Validation: Methodologies and Principles, Legal Implications and Issues**

### **Abstract**

Forensic tools are critical when it comes to digital investigations, yet many of them are used without any sort of formal validation which then risks errors and challenges in court. This proposal aims to test hypotheses about forensic tool accuracies and their reliability by designing and applying a validation framework to open-source forensic tools. The first specific aim is to survey the existing validation standards and practices. The second specific aim is to conduct experiments on selected tools using controlled data to measure artifact extraction accuracy, metadata integrity, and repeatability. Together, these aims will produce practical, repeatable guidelines that smaller labs can adopt to validate tools effectively.

### **Introduction**

Digital forensics as a field depends heavily on software tools that extract and interpret data from devices. If these tools produce invalid or inconsistent results, the integrity of the data found from the forensic findings is compromised. Legal proceedings, criminal investigations, and civil cases all rely on the forensic tools and their results. Many labs that are smaller or regional lack standard processes to test and verify the tools they rely on.

This research will focus on validating forensic tools by combining literature survey with some testing, which aims to reveal how well current tools perform on typical forensic tasks and what labs can do to ensure the same level of reliability. This paper will contribute by outlining a lightweight validation framework that balances rigor with feasibility for smaller labs.

### **Hypothesis**

Forensic tools commonly used in investigations have measurable limitations when it comes to artifact extraction and metadata preservation. Applying a simple, reproducible validation framework will expose those limitations and further improve such tools.

### **Specific Aims**

1. Review and compare existing standards, practices, and guidelines for forensic tool validation using NIST or SWGDE, including possible legal/court precedents.
2. Conduct experimental validation on specific open-source forensic tools using a small dataset to assess their accuracy, repeatability, and metadata integrity.

## Potential Pitfalls and Alternative Strategies

### Challenges

- Selected tools may not support all artifact types (deleted files, nested directories)
- Variability due to different versions or configurations of tools might change/hinder results
- Time constraints for experiments with large datasets or many test cases

### Alternative Strategies

- Limit test dataset to the artifact types that are supported. Additionally, document unsupported cases and then possibly include a commercial tool if available to fill in the gaps.
- Standardize using a specific tool version. Write down configurations. Repeat certain tests if needed. Furthermore, document if different version outputs vary too much.
- Using reasonably small but representative datasets. Emphasizing depth on fewer tools/artifact types rather than breadth.

## References

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